Fifteen minutes from sign-up to your first useful output.

A compressed first hour with Claude — the full guide is at choosewise.education.

Claude is a tool. You are the teacher. This page gives you the three things that separate a useful first session from a frustrating one: a working account, a prompt that does not waste your time, and the habit of iterating. Skim it once, apply it today, return for depth tomorrow.

1 Sign in at claude.ai

Go to *claude.ai* and sign up. You can sign in with Google or Apple, or create an account with any email address. To decide whether Claude is a useful tool for you, start with a free personal account — just don't upload sensitive data. If you conclude that your school should have Claude accounts, there are several steps to work through before you are up and running.

2 Write a prompt that works — the RTF anatomy

Most prompts fail because they are vague, not because the model is weak. A useful prompt names three things: Role, Task, Format.

R
Role

Who Claude should be. "An experienced Year 4 literacy teacher in a mixed-ability state school" beats "a teacher".

T
Task

Exactly what you want done. "A ten-minute retrieval quiz on persuasive techniques from the past three lessons" beats "help with a quiz".

F
Format

The shape of the answer. Count, question types, word limit, whether to include an answer key. Say it up front.

3 Iterate — the first draft is never the deliverable

Read the first output. Tell Claude two things to change. Run again. Ask for one more refinement. Two rounds of feedback take three minutes and roughly triple the quality. That iteration loop is the skill — not the perfect opening prompt.

BAD

Explain the water cycle.

BETTER

Explain the water cycle for Year 6. Make it easy to understand.

BEST

Act as a Year 6 Science teacher. Write a 250-word explanation of the water cycle for a mixed-ability class. Include the four stages, one real-world example each, a five-term vocabulary box, and three retrieval questions at the end.

Where the real leverage starts.

Set Claude up once. Benefit every conversation after.

Set up one Project — your persistent teaching assistant

Pick the subject or year you spend most of your time on. Create a Project in Claude, upload five reference files, and write one custom instruction. Every conversation inside that Project draws on the files and follows the instruction — you stop pasting context and start compounding it.

Upload these five:

· Your curriculum or syllabus for the subject and year

· Your scope and sequence or term planner

· Your school's style or communications guide

· An assessment rubric you use regularly

· Three de-identified student work samples

Add one instruction:

"You are an experienced Year 8 teacher in a mixed-ability school. Outputs should be classroom-ready, follow the uploaded style guide, never produce more than I asked for, and use British English."

Turn on Memory. Save two Styles.

Memory lets Claude remember your role, school, and formatting preferences across conversations. Open Settings → Memory, turn it on, and tell Claude about yourself in plain sentences over your first few chats. Every memory is reviewable and deletable.

Styles are voice presets. Save one called *Parent communication — warm, clear, no jargon* and another *Staff brief — concise, bullet-led*. Pick from the dropdown when you start a task. Three or four Styles cover eighty per cent of a teacher's recurring writing.

Five first wins — pick one this week

1 **Differentiate a reading passage**
Three versions at two years below, at-level, and two years above — same core ideas, shared key vocabulary.

2 **Build a retrieval quiz**
Topic, year level, number and mix of questions, answer key. Usable draft in two minutes.

3 **Draft a parent communication**
Give the context and the tone. Ask for two alternative tones to calibrate before you send.

4 **Summarise a long policy document**
Upload the PDF. Ask for the three things you actually need, what affects you, and any deadlines buried inside.

5 **Create a lesson starter**
Three starter options in different formats — vocabulary warm-up, sentence completion, think-pair-share.

• WATCH OUT · THINK BEFORE YOU SHARE

Public curriculum documents, policy PDFs, and your own lesson notes are usually fine to upload. Student names, grades, behavioural records, health information, parent contact details — never. De-identify everything. If a document is not clearly safe, treat it as unsafe and ask your school's data protection officer first.

Ready for depth? Read the full Educator's Guide to Claude — or download the premium PDF from the same page.

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